

INDIA IN THE INDO-PACIFIC: THREATS AND OPPORTUNITIES

Are we seeing outcomes out of the Quad? Yes, we are. Trust mechanisms are being created. We think, on the cyber side, the Quad mechanism has got quite far

RUDRA CHAUDHURI
Director, Carnegie India

TECHNOLOGY GROWTH IN NEW-AGE SEGMENTS AND TECHNOLOGY SOVEREIGNTY IS THE ANSWER FOR INDIA TO ENSURE SECURITY IN THE INDO-PACIFIC

AIR CHIEF MARSHAL R.K.S. BHADAURIA (RETD)
Former Chief of Air staff

India can be a very important force for global good. If we can skill the young, there is so much they can contribute to the Indo-Pacific region

TARANJIT SINGH SANDHU
Former Indian Ambassador to the US

AI is the largest source of power that India can get quickly. We want to invest in India in AI, in defence tech, including autonomous warfare tech, but we need to overcome obstacles in the way

ASHA JADEJA MOTWANI, *Founder, Motwani Jadeja Foundation*

them and evolving ways to leverage them militarily.

Pointing out China's enormous naval power, former navy chief Adm. Sunil Lanba said that to counter this, India must invest towards becoming a national maritime power—in merchant shipping construction as well as blue water forces, especially destroyers, frigates, a third heavy aircraft carrier and nuclear submarines. In the light of recent events in the Maldives, Adm. Lanba noted that India has a radar chain in Mauritius, Sri Lanka, Seychelles etc., signed white shipping agreements with 20 countries and has intelligence-sharing agreements with the US and others. "There is a holistic domain awareness of what's happening in the Indo-Pacific," Adm. Lanba said. Former chief of the Indian Air Force, Air Chief Marshal R.K.S. Bhadauria spoke about how India needs to transform its capabilities in the air and space domains, especially in intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance (ISR) and tactical navigation (NAV). Like Gen. Pande, he, too, spoke about beefing up India's home-grown AI, ML and Quantum tech capabilities. "For security in the Indo-Pacific, India needs to take leadership in these new techs," he said.

On how to manage the relationship with China, former foreign secretary Nirupama Rao said that since there is a trust deficit, the Indo-Pacific assumes importance. It is here that India and its Quad partners Australia, Japan and the US are trying to create a new dynamic of multilateralism—more cooperative structures and more collaborative security. She pointed out that 49 countries of the Global South are part of the region, and India must engage with them. "The contours of the relationships that we build in the Indo-Pacific are being determined in many ways by the contradictions and confrontations we have with China today," she said. While dealing with China, diplomacy and deterrence are a potent force, she said.

The Quad featured prominently in the comments of former Indian ambassador to the US Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Carnegie India director Rudra Chaudhuri. Pointing out that India-US relations are robust not just in security matters but also in healthcare, tech start-ups and that industry-government linkages that are given a fillip through the US-India Initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology (iCET), Sandhu said this has importance with regard to the Indo-Pacific region through Quad. Chaudhuri elaborated that the Quad also had working groups on infrastructure, health, climate change, supply chain resilience and others. All this strengthens democracy/ good governance, which is essential to counter the China challenge.

Investor and philanthropist Asha Jadeja Motwani, founder of the Motwani Jadeja Foundation, said that venture capitalists like her are investing in defence tech, and that AI is the most important component of that as it is going to be the largest source of power. However, she expressed dismay at Indian bureaucracy's purported plans to over-regulate AI. Chaudhuri contradicted her, though, saying that the Indian government has taken a forward-looking position on AI and is not trying to over-regulate it.

The last word on how to combat threats from China in the Indo-Pacific came from the army chief. "We need to be strong—it will deter our adversaries and not impede the nation's growth trajectory," said Gen. Pande. ■